

BENEATH THE LIES

By
Aman Fatima

"Every lie hides a truth,
and every truth has a price."

Chapter One

The Message

Elara had learned one thing very early in life: trust could be dangerous.

The city looked beautiful from the outside. Bright lights filled the streets, people laughed in cafés, and children played in the parks. But behind every smile, there could be a secret.

As Elara walked home from school that evening, her phone suddenly vibrated.

Unknown Number: *"I know what happened three years ago."*

Elara froze.

Three years ago was a time she had promised never to remember again.

Before she could reply, another message appeared.

Unknown Number: *"If you want the truth, come to the old library at midnight. Come alone."*

A cold shiver ran down Elara's spine.

Someone knew her secret.....

Elara stared at the screen, reading the message again and again.

"I know what happened three years ago."

her hands began to shake.

No one was supposed to know.

For a moment, Elara thought about deleting the messages and pretending she had never seen them. But curiosity was stronger than fear.

At exactly midnight, Elara stood in front of the old library.

The building had been abandoned for years. Its broken windows looked like dark eyes watching from the shadows.

The door slowly creaked open.

"Hello?" Elara called out.

No answer.

Then...

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Footsteps echoed from the second floor.

Elara's heart pounded.

She climbed the dusty stairs and found a single envelope lying on the floor.

On the front, written in red ink, were the words:

"The truth starts here."

With trembling hands, Elara opened it.

Inside was an old photograph.

It showed five teenagers standing together.

Elara recognized four of them immediately.

The fifth person's face had been scratched out.

Suddenly, a voice came from the darkness.

"You finally came."

Elara spun around.

A figure stepped out of the shadows, his face hidden by a black hood.

"You don't remember me, do you?" the stranger asked.

Before Elara could answer, the lights in the library went out.

Everything became silent.

"You don't remember that night," Roman said quietly. "But I do.

Before Elara could ask another question, a loud creak echoed somewhere in the library.

Roman stopped talking.

Another sound followed.

A faint thud.

Elara frowned. "What was that?"

Roman's expression suddenly changed.

He looked toward the dark hallway, listening carefully.

Then...

Tap.

A footstep.

His eyes widened.

Without saying a word, he grabbed Elara's hand and pulled her into a small storage room beside the shelves.

"Roman, what are you doing?" she whispered.

"Shh," he said, closing the door halfway.

Another footstep echoed through the library.

Roman's grip on her hand tightened.

"I think we're not alone," he whispered.

Elara's heart began to race.

"What do you mean?"

Roman looked toward the crack in the door.

"I think... there's a third person here."

Silence.

Then the sound of footsteps slowly moved closer.

Neither of them dared to breathe.

The footsteps came closer.

Roman placed a hand over her mouth.

"Don't make a sound," he whispered.

The footsteps stopped right outside the door.

Silence.

Elara could hear her own heartbeat.

A few seconds passed.

Then the footsteps slowly moved away.

Roman waited a little longer before taking his hand away.

"Who was that?" Elara asked softly.

Roman looked at the dark hallway, his expression unreadable.

"I don't know," he said quietly.

He took a deep breath.

"But this means we're too late."

"What do you mean?"

Roman turned to look at her.

"Someone else is looking for the truth before us."

Roman slowly pointed toward the old wooden door.

"Everything started in that room," he said quietly. "And everything ended there too."

Elara stared at the door, a strange feeling rising in her chest.

Then she looked at him.

"I don't know why," she said softly, "but ever since that night... I've hated you."

Roman's expression froze.

"When I look at you, my heart feels heavy. I feel angry... and I don't even know the reason."

Silence filled the hallway.

"I don't remember what happened," Elara whispered, "but a part of me keeps telling me to stay away from you."

Roman lowered his eyes.

A painful smile appeared on his face.

"I know," he said quietly.

And somehow... those words hurt more than anything else.

"I know," Roman said quietly.

Elara frowned.

"You know?" she repeated. "Then tell me. Tell me what happened that night."

Roman looked at her for a long moment.

"I can't."

"Why not?" she asked, her voice rising.

"Because if I tell you now, you'll hate me even more."

A cold breeze passed through the hallway.

Elara crossed her arms.

"I already hate you."

For a second, something painful flashed in Roman's eyes.

"That's the problem, Elara," he said softly. "You hate me... but you don't even remember why."

She looked away.

For some reason, seeing the hurt in his eyes made her chest ache.

Roman took a step toward the old door.

"The answers you're looking for are behind this door."

Elara looked at it nervously.

"And if I don't like the truth?"

Roman's hand stopped on the doorknob.

He turned back to her.

"Then you'll understand why I stayed away for three years."

Silence.

Neither of them moved.

Then, slowly, Roman placed his hand on the handle.

"Are you ready?" he asked.

Elara took a deep breath and looked at the door.

She wasn't sure if she wanted her memories back.

But she nodded anyway.